

A single copy of Matthew would be falling apart before it got to the twentieth congregation (if on papyrus).

But why do I insist on papyrus instead of parchment? Well, a single copy of Matthew would represent around fifteen sheep or goats; on that basis, who could afford multiple copies? That said, however, the master copy may indeed have been done on parchment, for two reasons: if a master copy was to be kept, for quality control, it should be on durable material; if multiple copies of the master copy were to be made before turning it loose to the public, a master copy on papyrus could not last.

The idea of publishing a book in the form of multiple copies may be inferred from the Epistles. 2 Corinthians was written to “the church of God which is at Corinth, with all the saints who are in all Achaia” (verse 1). How many congregations would there have been “in all Achaia”? Was Paul thinking of multiple copies? 1 Corinthians was addressed to “all those everywhere who call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ” (verse 2). Now how many copies would **that** take? Galatians was written to “the churches of Galatia” (verse 2). Could a single copy get to all of them?

Consider the case of Peter’s first letter: it is addressed to believers in “Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia and Bithynia” (verse 1). Well now, what basis could Peter (apostle to the circumcised, Galatians 2:8) have for writing to people in those places? Probably a good number of the older leaders had been with Peter at Pentecost, and had sat under his ministry until the persecution under Saul sent them packing back home, presumably (Acts 8:4). Notice that the list of places in Acts 2:9-11 includes the following places in Asia Minor: Asia, Cappadocia, Pamphylia, Phrygia and Pontus. Three of the five are in Peter’s list, and we need not assume that his list was exhaustive; for that matter, the list in Acts 2:9-11 is probably not exhaustive.

Have you ever looked at a map to see the location of Peter’s five provinces? They basically represent the whole of Asia Minor (today’s Turkey)! ‘Asia’ seems to have been used in different ways. Acts 27:2 has Asia including Cilicia and Pamphylia (verse 5). The glorified Christ put the seven churches in Asia (Revelation 1:4). In Acts 16:6 the term seems to refer to a more limited area, which, however, presumably included Ephesus, to which Paul returned later. Proconsular Asia included Mysia and Phrygia. Now how many congregations would there have been in all of Asia Minor? And how could a single copy get around to all of them? If the letter was written on papyrus (as seems likely—cheaper, more abundant) it would be falling apart by the time it got to the twentieth congregation, if not before (papyrus cannot stand all that much handling).